

AI Unit Economics Worksheet

Measure the cost of a successful business outcome, then test what changes at scale.

Choose a unit the business understands

Use one workload and one measurement period per worksheet. Bring engineering, product and finance together to agree the cost boundary and acceptance criteria before comparing models or vendors.

Workload and business unit

Examples: resolved support case, approved claim or accepted design. Define yours:

Accepted outcome

Quality, latency and control conditions that must all be met to count as success:

Measurement scope

Period / currency / workload segment / data source / finance owner / technical owner:

The central calculation

Cost per accepted outcome = total attributable operating cost divided by accepted outcomes. Keep one-time investment visible separately, and state any amortization assumption.

Companion to Jengara's "From tokens to gross margin." This printable worksheet contains formulas and blank inputs; it does not calculate automatically.

Count the whole workload

Include failed and abandoned attempts. Avoid charging a shared cost twice.

Cost category	Period cost	Allocation / source
Model inference and embeddings		
Retrieval, storage and data movement		
Orchestration and external tools		
Evaluation, observability and controls		
Compute / accelerator capacity		
Human review and exception handling		
Platform operations and support		

Total attributable operating cost

Sum the rows in one currency and period. Record excluded costs and why:

Allocation rule: specify whether shared costs are assigned by usage, capacity, customer, time or another defensible driver. Reconcile the total to the agreed source records.

Measure accepted work

Keep business outcomes separate from API calls, attempts and technical completions.

Measure	Value	Definition / source
Business units initiated		
Attempts, including retries		
Technically completed units		
Accepted business outcomes		
Human review hours		

Calculate with matching boundaries

Acceptance rate = accepted outcomes / business units initiated.

Attempts per accepted outcome = total attempts / accepted outcomes.

Operating cost per accepted outcome = period cost / accepted outcomes.

Review cost = review hours x fully loaded hourly cost.

Interpretation and limitations

If accepted outcomes are zero, unit cost is undefined. Record quality failures and exclusions:

Check that the numerator and denominator describe the same workload and period. Do not substitute requests or generated tokens for successful business outcomes.

Test the assumptions that move value

Enter a base case and two explicit alternatives. These are estimates until measured.

Input / output	Base	Downside	Improved
Monthly business volume			
Acceptance rate			
Attempts per outcome			
Variable operating cost			
Fixed operating cost			
Accepted outcomes			
Cost per accepted outcome			

Explain each change

Adoption, context size, retry behavior, model routing, review effort or vendor price:

When volume changes, separate fixed from variable cost. Record whether capacity grows in steps. Validate quality again when changing models, caching or routing.

DECISION / 05

Connect cost to business value

Decide what to optimize, who owns it and how value will be demonstrated.

Value model

Revenue or avoided cost per accepted outcome, evidence source and realization mechanism:

Margin or benefit bridge

Attributable value minus attributable cost. State other costs needed for a gross-margin claim:

Action	Owner	Success / review date
Engineering efficiency		
Product acceptance and adoption		
Finance allocation and budget		

Decision gate

Scale only after outcome quality, full cost and operational ownership are evidenced. Set an exception threshold and a review date; revisit assumptions when the workload changes.

Source: jengara.ai/insights/token-cost-gross-margin/

Original Jengara operating approach informed by FinOps unit-economics guidance. No vendor prices or empirical performance claims are assumed. Version 1.0 / September 2026.